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From the editor-in-chief

Rule No.1 of journalism: there are no gods. And if they appear to be so they usually have feet of clay. So it was with a fast-talking dynamic 46-year-old man who came from nowhere three years ago and became the god of cricket in India. This is none other than Indian Premier League (IPL) Commissioner Lalit Modi who is today embroiled in controversy. It is rare for INDIA TODAY to fete someone on the cover for spectacular achievement and then put them on it within the same month for being in trouble. It was, however, inevitable as the IPL is not only a phenomenon that has revolutionised cricket but last week shook the Government and led to the exit of one of its ministers. Such is perceived to be the importance of all this that senior members of the Union Cabinet have got involved in sorting out the affairs of what is essentially a cricket club.

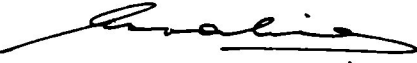
But this is no ordinary cricket club, especially since the creation of the IPL. The IPL has become a sporting and entertainment spectacle called the "world's hottest sports league" and is valued as a \$4.13-billion brand. Its eight teams are owned by very big names in Indian business and cinema. All the world's cricket stars were a part of it or trying hard to be. Last year, when the Lok Sabha elections posed a threat, the IPL successfully moved to South Africa within three weeks. IPL-3 is even bigger than the previous two and is expected to generate revenues of Rs 1,170 crore for the cricket club besides all the money earned by players and team owners. The IPL is the most glamorous and efficient gravy train for cricket in the world.

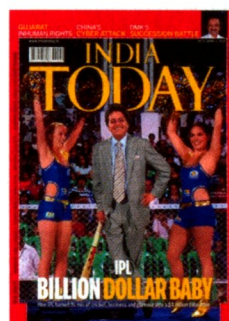
The trouble began when the bidding process for the creation of two new teams in the league began. With it opened the IPL's own can of worms. The dashing, twittering Shashi Tharoor, minister of state for external affairs, resigned after a bitter dispute with Modi over his role in setting up the controversial Kochi consortium.

Once Tharoor was gone, Modi's problems began. Skeletons tumbled out as attention was turned on the IPL. The event that Modi had boldly created with his deep involvement at every level of its functioning had now put him in the dock. Tax raids have been conducted at his offices.

Under scrutiny now are the conflicts of interest within the IPL, its line of funding that is traced to questionable offshore accounts in Mauritius and the Cayman Islands, contracts awarded to individuals linked to Modi or his closest associates or even relatives of politicians. Modi is no stranger to controversy, the last being the non-selection of Pakistani players. At present he is in a defiant mood and in his fight for survival has revealed the shenanigans of others.

Our cover story this week is a thorough and complete analysis of the IPL scandal from the Tharoor episode to the move to oust Modi. The great pity in India is that creations like the IPL become a victim of their own success. It breeds large egos amongst those in charge who then run the institutions like personal fiefdoms. Where there is money involved, especially large sums, corruption is not far behind. Also, we have seen that politicians too cannot keep their sticky fingers out of sports bodies, which should be discouraged. Hopefully, after the dust has settled in the Tharoor-Modi affair some lessons will be learned in having greater transparency in the workings of such organisations.


(Aroon Purie)



OUR APRIL 2010
COVER ON THE IPL